

37 Nadab and Abihu

Aaron's two oldest sons, who saw God on the mountain and died for offering "strange fire."

Nadab and Abihu were the two oldest sons of Aaron, Israel's first high priest. Few were given more privilege. They climbed Sinai with Moses and the elders, saw the God of Israel, and ate and drank in his presence. They were ordained as priests and served at the first sacrifices in the tabernacle. Then, on that very day or soon after, they offered "strange fire before the LORD, which he commanded them not," and fire from the LORD killed them. Their story shows that God's nearness must be treated as holy.

At a glance

Names	Nadab, probably "generous"; Abihu, "he is my father"
Family	Sons of Aaron and Elisheba (Exodus 6:23)
Role	Priests, ordained with their father (Exodus 28:1; Leviticus 8)
When	At Sinai, c. 1446–1445 BC on the early date (see the Timeline note)
Children	None (Numbers 3:4; 1 Chronicles 24:2)
Not the same as	Nadab, king of Israel (1 Kings 15:25)
Main passages	Exodus 24:1, 9–11; Leviticus 10:1–7
New Testament	Not named

"Then Moses said unto Aaron, This is it that the LORD spake, saying, I will be sanctified in them that come nigh me, and before all the people I will be glorified. And Aaron held his peace."

Leviticus 10:3, KJV

The life of Nadab and Abihu

Dates are approximate (BC) and follow the early Exodus date, c. 1446 BC. On the late date, move them about 185 years later. Leviticus 10 seems to follow straight after the eighth day of the ordination (Leviticus 9:1), but the exact day is not stated.

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| In Egypt | ● Born to Aaron |
| | Aaron marries Elisheba, and she bears Nadab, Abihu, Eleazar and Ithamar. Nadab is the firstborn. <i>Exodus 6:23; Numbers 3:2</i> |
| c. 1446 BC
At Sinai | ● See the God of Israel |
| | They are called up the mountain with Moses, Aaron and seventy elders. They see the God of Israel, and they eat and drink before him. <i>Exodus 24:1, 9–11</i> |
| c. 1446 BC
At Sinai | ● Chosen as priests |
| | God tells Moses to set apart Aaron and his four sons to serve as priests, with holy garments made for them. <i>Exodus 28:1–4, 40–43</i> |
| c. 1445 BC
Second year | ● Ordained |
| | Moses washes, clothes and anoints them with their father. For seven days they stay at the door of the tabernacle. <i>Leviticus 8:1–36</i> |
| c. 1445 BC
The eighth day | ● The first service |
| | They help Aaron offer the first sacrifices. The glory of the LORD appears, and fire comes out from the LORD and consumes the offering. <i>Leviticus 9:1, 8–24</i> |
| c. 1445 BC
Soon after | ● Strange fire |
| | Each takes his censer, puts fire and incense in it, and offers strange fire. Fire from the LORD devours them. Two of Aaron's cousins carry them out of the camp in their coats. <i>Leviticus 10:1–5</i> |

Key activities

Scripture does not say exactly what made the fire "strange." Suggestions include fire not taken from the altar, incense offered at the wrong time or place, or acting without being told. Because God warns priests against wine right afterward (Leviticus 10:8–11), some think they were drunk. The text does not settle it.

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- 1 **Went up the mountain.** They were among the few invited to come near on Sinai. *Exodus 24:1, 9*
 - 2 **Saw God and ate before him.** "They saw God, and did eat and drink." *Exodus 24:10–11*
 - 3 **Were set apart as priests.** They were clothed, anointed and ordained with their father. *Exodus 28:1; Leviticus 8:13, 30*
 - 4 **Served at the first sacrifices.** They brought the blood to Aaron at the altar. *Leviticus 9:9, 12, 18*
 - 5 **Offered strange fire.** Each took his own censer and offered fire "which he commanded them not." *Leviticus 10:1*
 - 6 **Died before the LORD.** "There went out fire from the LORD, and devoured them." *Leviticus 10:2*
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Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Nadab and Abihu.

Old Testament

Exodus 6:23; 28:1	Their birth and calling as priests
Exodus 24:1, 9–11	They see God on the mountain
Leviticus 10:1–7	Their death and Aaron's silent grief
Leviticus 16:1–2	Atonement rules "after the death of the two sons of Aaron"
Numbers 3:2–4; 1 Chronicles 24:1–2	Childless; Eleazar and Ithamar carry on
Echo: 2 Samuel 6:6–7	Uzzah dies for touching the ark
Echo: 2 Chronicles 26:16–21	Uzziah struck for burning incense

New Testament

Echoes	Ananias and Sapphira die for lying to the Holy Spirit (Acts 5:1–11). "Our God is a consuming fire" (Hebrews 12:28–29). Through Christ believers may now "come boldly unto the throne of grace" (Hebrews 4:16).
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For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did Nadab and Abihu experience in Exodus 24:9–11, and what did they do in Leviticus 10:1?
2. *Understand:* Why do you think God judged them so severely, and so quickly?
3. *Apply:* Nadab and Abihu had been given great closeness to God. Where might you have grown careless with worship or prayer?
4. *Apply:* Aaron "held his peace" in his grief. How can your group support someone facing a loss they cannot explain?